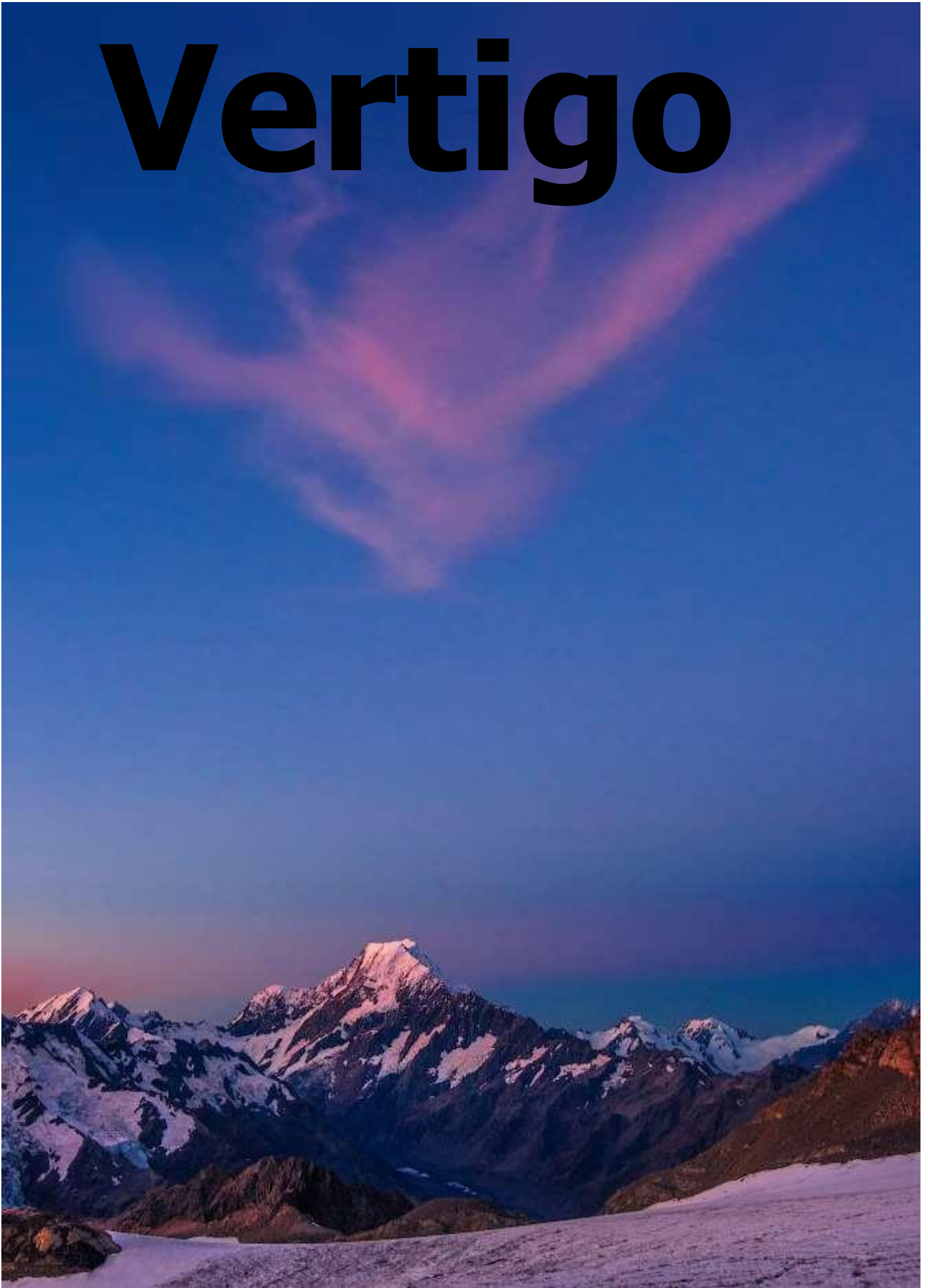


Vertigo



Dusk view of Le Perouse, Hicks, Cook, the Minarets and Elie De Beaumont from the Annette Plateau (photo by Peter Laurensen)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club - Wellington Section

www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Twitter @NZACWellington

Section News

May Section Night

South Island traverse 2016/17

Alexis Belton was a member of the team who carried out a South Island traverse recently. Alexis will show a presentation and talk about the team's 4 month traverse of the South Island of New Zealand from Cape Farewell to Foveaux Strait.



Lake Pouteriteri



Frew Saddle

Come hear about the highs and lows of life on the tour in the mountains of the South Island during the wettest summers in years. Travelling mostly by foot, but also by bike, kayak and packraft, our route took us through the undervalued splendours Kahurangi, the mighty South Alps and the depths of south-western Fiordland.

Please don't forget the koha for section night – there'll be an ice bucket at the entry door for that purpose. 😊

Chairs Report April 2017

There has been a bit of debate about what to do about the section night venue. It seems the old farts don't like it because they can't hear the speakers when the music starts, I include myself in that group. On the other hand, it's close to the CBD, is cozy and has a good range of food and drink. Some think the food and drink aren't that much of an issue nor the location. I'm not so sure about that. It's good to be able to get a drink and not have to go too far. If it wasn't for the music, our current venue would be about right. We have tried negotiating but they won't shift the music to a later start. We've been on the hunt for a better location for the past year and think we have found something suitable. The Third Eye at 30 Arthur St, Te Aro. This has a dedicated space (no music to drown out speakers), is still in the CBD, has good AV facilities, has a bar, snacks, reasonable parking and is just around the corner from the Southern Cross. We plan to try it out for the July Section night (May - not enough notice - June Banff).

There have also been suggestions that we should consider making the start time a bit later from 6pm to 6:30pm or 7pm. The few straw polls I've held at section nights indicate that most people are happy with the 6pm start as they tend to come direct from work - but then they are the ones that turn up so perhaps there are others that would prefer a later start time. If you do, let me know.

Another thing that came up in the survey was that section trips and section nights are very important to many of you. This isn't consistent with what we're seeing. So, either the question wasn't worded well or perhaps we have a group of members who think trips and section nights are important but not for them?

If you have any comments on what you liked or didn't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us @NZACWellington or post a message on our facebook page www.facebook.com/nzacwellington.

Finally: "When you see someone putting on his Big Boots, you can be pretty sure that an Adventure is going to happen." A.A Milne, Winnie-the-Pooh

Simon

Chair: NZAC Wellington

For quick access to the section's page on the NZAC website, scan the below QR code.



Gear Hire

Don't forget the section has gear for hire : avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes and PLBs. If you're keen to hire some gear please fill in the form [here](#). Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on its return. The section is continuing to upgrade gear with new helmets, crampons and a couple of entry level ice hammers among the more recent purchases.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Vertigo Articles

At our last section night, those who attended indicated they like reading trip reports in Vertigo. It was pointed out that for that to happen, members need to be writing up their trips and sending them through. Reports don't need to be long and detailed and the trips don't need to be earth-shatteringly hard trips. So, write a few words, send through photos – don't worry about finessing the layout etc. Just dash off a few paragraphs in an email and attach a couple of photos (with appropriate captions) and send through to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz. Also, if you have a great photo (portrait layout) for the front page of Vertigo send it through. Closing date for submissions each month is the weekend before the last Wednesday of the month allowing publishing to happen a week before section night.

Cheers, Carolyn

Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips, Courses and Events

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs are covered by the section. If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or know more email us on wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the committee can help with advertising / logistics.

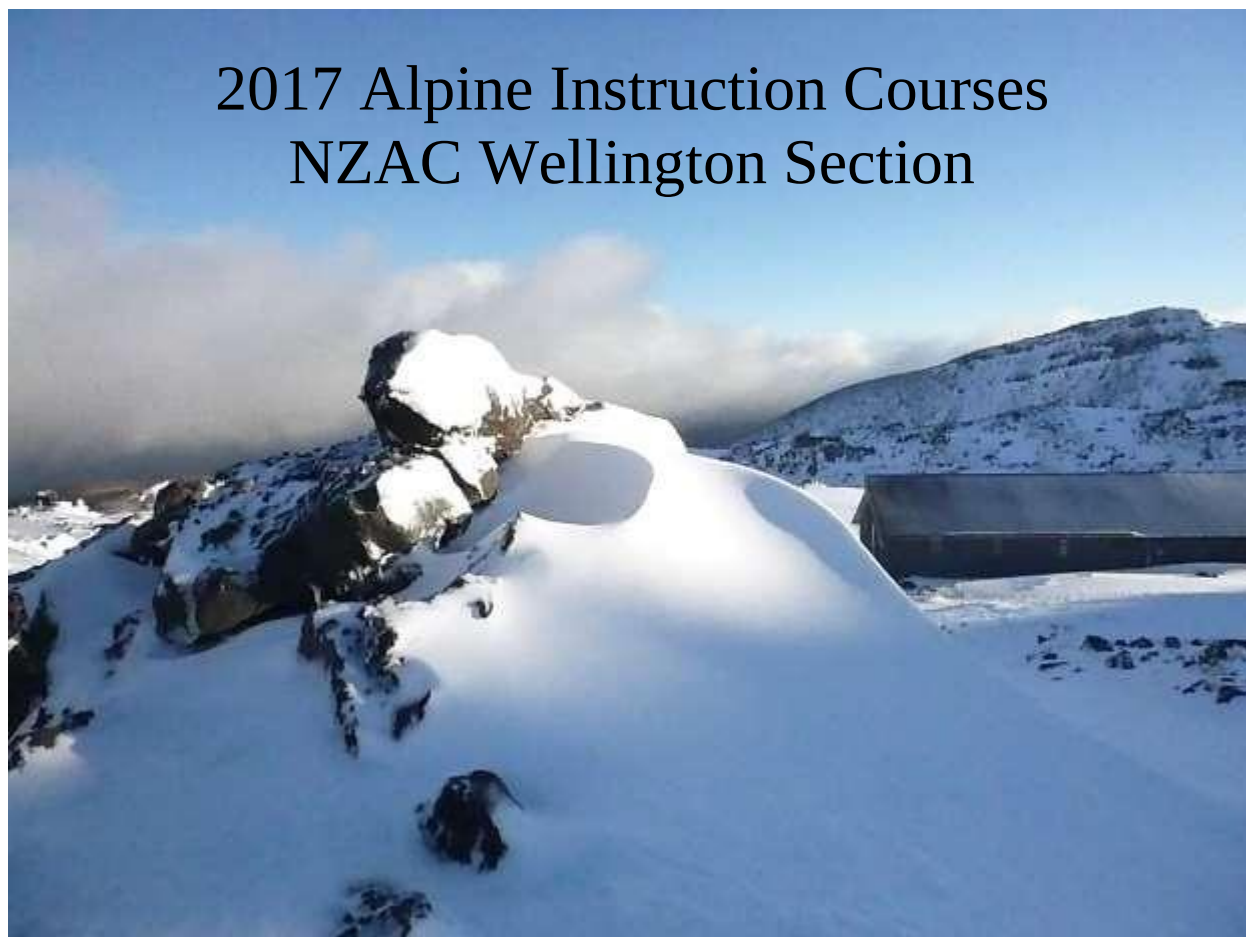
When?	Where?
Queen's Birthday	Mt Hopeless, Nelson Lakes
30 May	BANFF Programme A – 1 st screening, 6pm
7 June	BANFF Programme B – 1 st screening, 6pm
14 June	BANFF Programme A – 2 nd screening, 6pm
25 June	BANFF Programme B – 2 nd screening, 1pm
30 June – 2 July	North Island Ice Climbing Meet, Tukino
21-23 July	Beginner level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu
28-30 July	Beginner level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu
18-20 August	Beginner / Intermediate level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu
25-27 August	Intermediate / Advanced level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu
6-8 October	North Island Ski Touring Meet, Tukino
Labour Weekend – 21-23 October	Mt Somers
November	Aspiring Take 2

Mt Hopeless, Queen's Birthday Weekend

The loose plan for this trip is as follows:

Travel on the ferry on Friday night picking up a rental vehicle in Picton. Water taxi on Saturday morning across the lake and walk into Hopeless Hut. Climb on Sunday, walk out, water taxi and ferry home on Monday. The exact details will be confirmed in discussion with those interested in coming along. If you're interested or have questions send them through to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or talk to Simon or Carolyn at the next section night.

2017 Snowcraft Courses



When?

21-23 July	Beginner Course
28-30 July	Beginner Course
18-20 August	Beginner / Intermediate Courses
25-27 August	Intermediate / Advanced Courses

Where?

Whakapapa skifield, Mt Ruapehu

How much?

\$275 – includes accommodation, food and instruction

What's it about?

Choose the Beginner level course if you've had little to no experience in an alpine environment. The focus is on personal preparation and safe movement on snow. If you have a bit of experience in alpine terrain and are looking for an entry-level course in mountaineering come along to an Intermediate Snowcraft Course. This course introduces the use of ropes, harnesses and anchors required for protection when travelling in steeper terrain. If you've spent some time in an alpine environment and you're comfortable with using ropes and building snow anchors then the Advanced course develops further techniques in mountaineering to access more routes.

Course Structure

The practical component of each course is run over a weekend arriving at the lodge on Ruapehu on a Friday night and departing the mountain mid-afternoon on the Sunday. There's a theory evening held in Wellington on the Thursday night a week before the weekend away. The theory evening will cover gear requirements, logistics, weather and risk. The section has some of the gear you'll need available for hire at \$20 for the weekend, including helmets, ice axes, crampons and avalanche equipment.

Register your interest [here](#) or send your questions via email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz – you'll be sent the registration form to complete.

BANFF Mountain Film Festival 2017



That time of the year is coming up fast – movies from the BANFF Mountain Film Festival will be screening at the Paramount Theatre in Wellington in May and June. We have two programmes of movies to screen and two dates have been set for each programme as follows :

Programme A : 6:00pm Tuesday May 30th
6:00pm Wednesday June 14th
Programme B : 6:00pm Wednesday June 7th
1:00pm Sunday June 25th

Tickets are not yet on sale and the programme is not available on the banff.nz website yet – keep an eye on the website, your email and Facebook for updates.

North Island Ice Climbing Meet

Location: TASC Lodge, Tukino Ski Field, Mt Ruapehu

Date: Weekend of June 30 - July 2 , 2017



Cost: \$89 for the weekend (this covers accommodation – Friday and Saturday, breakfast and lunch on Saturday and Sunday, and Saturday night’s dinner)

This is a climbing meet so you are expected to organize your own climbing partners and transport to TASC lodge (4WD plus snow chains required!).

To book your place follow these instructions : go to <https://tukino.checkfront.com/reserve> and select start date 30 June.

 **Tukino Ski Area** Secure Online Booking

Welcome to Tukino - First to see the sun

Start: 30/06/17

End: 02/07/17

Keyword:

JUNE 2017

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
28	29	30	1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8	9	10	11
12	13	14	15	16	17	18
19	20	21	22	23	24	25
26	27	28	29	30	1	2

Friday June 30

New Booking: Fri Jun 30 - Sun Jul 2, 2017

[Ski & Stay](#) [Aorangi Ski Club](#) [Desert Alpine Club](#) [TASC Tukino Lodge](#) [NZAC Events at Tukino](#)

[Working Bee](#)

17 AVAILABLE

☒ Book Now

☐ Details

☐ Availability

NZAC Ice Climbing Meet

NZAC Ice Climbing Meet 2017 June 30th to 2nd July

Select NZAC Events at Tukino, under "NZAC Ice Climbing Meet" select "Book Now"
Make sure you enter Check-in date 30 /6/2017 and Check-out date 2/7/2017.

Details Availability **Book Now**

NZAC Ice Climbing Meet
Fri Jun 30 - Sun Jul 2, 2017

✓ 17 Available

Check-in 30/06/17

Check-out 02/07/17

NZAC Section - Wellington 1 x \$44.50

NZAC Section - Auckland 0 x \$44.50

NZAC Section - Central North Island 0 x \$44.50

NZAC Section - Other 0 x \$44.50

NZAC - Non Member 0 x \$65.00

Fri Jun 30 2017 - Sun Jul 2 2017: **\$89.00**

Apply Promo or Voucher Close Continue

The event organiser will get an email notifying them of your booking. They will confirm your booking. Payment instructions will be on the Booking email. Email receipts of payments will be sent. You will be sent information relating to the meeting by email closer to the weekend.

Check out our Ice Cameras

Margaret's Leap area <http://tukinoalpinesportsclub.org.nz/latest.jpg> and Bowl Wobbler Area <http://tukinoalpinesportsclub.org.nz/latest2.jpg>

Contact Eric Duggan (021 350 161) or ericduggan@gmail.com for more information.

See <http://climbnz.org.nz/nz/ni/tongariro/mt-ruapehu/tukino> for information about climbs.



All photos by Jonathan Cook

North Island Ski Touring Meet

The North Island ski touring meet will take place at Tukino Ski Field, Mt Ruapehu on the weekend of 6-8 October 2017. Further details will be made available on the national website [here](#) and on Facebook.

Outdoor Training NZ Courses

OTNZ Wellington are running training courses as follows:

- Risk Management (24-25 June) - \$70
- Advanced Bushcraft (2-3 September)
- Intermediate Bushcraft (16-17 September)
- Navigation (6 and 11 November)
- River Safety (3 December)

More information on these courses and how to book your place can be found on <http://www.outdoortraining.nz/courses/courses.php>.

Trips

Humbled again. A visit to Annette Plateau

Words and pictures Peter Laurenson

This last year has been one of constantly changing weather, although it seems that February and March are the most settled months these days. It was nearing the end of March so Mike Neely, a fellow NZAC Wellington Section member, and I committed to a trip south in the last week of March, hoping to climb Mitre Peak in Milford Sound if conditions permitted. I've learnt though that it's wise not to be too fixated on a single objective. If you want to optimise your chances to climb something it's best to chase the weather. Our plan B was the Mount Cook region, where it's still possible to do something east of the Main Divide if the weather on the west, or further south is dodgy.

And, so it was on our arrival in Queenstown – cloud and wind forecast for Fiordland, which didn't sound great for the exposed ridge leading to the top of Mitre Peak. But things looked better up around Mount Cook. I had wanted to do the circuit up the Sebastopol Ridge to access the Annette Plateau, climb something up there and then return via Mount Kitchener and Mueller Hut for some time. So this is what we decided to do, hopefully including a climb of Mount Sealy while camped up on the Plateau.



On top of Sebastopol (1,468m), looking north over Wakefield Ridge to Mt Sefton and Mt Cook

Day one dawned with what seemed to be dense cloud, which didn't fit the weather forecast indicating fine weather for the coming three days. We set off from the road end at the base of Mount Sebastopol at 8am and made quick progress up the tourist trail to the Red Tarn. As we ascended, to our delight we soon breached the foggy cloud blanketing the entire valley and climbed into a perfect bluebird day. The sweat was soon dripping on the sustained, steep haul up to the top of Sebastopol with our heavy packs. It took a couple of hours to get to the top (1,468m), but our effort was rewarded with a crystal clear view of our intended route, as well as a 360 degree panorama of the national park.

The top hundred or so metres of Sebastopol are quite steep and craggy, demanding focus and care in places. The terrain was very dry, with a lot of loose, shattered rock about. This remained the case during our entire trip and presented one of the biggest hazards facing us. Beyond Sebastopol, we reached a dip in the ridge before recommencing our ascent. It was fairly gradual and undulating, resembling a ridge top in the Tararuas for a couple of hours, but then things got more interesting at about 1,750m. This is where the ridge becomes a serrated knife edge of rock teeth. We found our way onto the north side of the ridge, picking our way around bluffs and across little shelves.



On the north side of the craggy upper section of Sebastopol Ridge

At one point we had to get the rope out to abseil into a small chasm, thereby avoiding an exposed move around a corner that was less than generous with hand holds.



Mike demonstrating the awkward abseil technique



On the headwall right of Sebastopol Ridge

Progress was slower than we'd anticipated and we found ourselves at the top of the rock teeth about 2pm. Although the route from there up onto the Plateau is meant to go left across and up a crevassed snow slope, we opted for what looked to be a straight forward headwall of snow to the right. We could see that it steepened near the top but I thought we could follow the rock on the far side to the top okay.

The headwall turned out to be a bit of a baby-faced assassin. As we climbed, the gradient quietly increased, creeping up on us. As we neared the top, hidden crevasses became apparent as we kicked with increasing concern into the steep snow. It wasn't a spot to put in a viable snow anchor and the notion of retreat wasn't too appealing either. As the gradient reached somewhere near seventy degrees I realised that a fall now was not an option. My heart was pounding as I cleared the lip, only to find myself on top of a series of crevasses. Not pretty, but after taking some deep breaths I could see that safety was just a few careful steps away. I shouted back to Mike to get a stable stance and I'd send down the rope end for him to tie in to. My belay point around the biggest rock I could find amongst a sea of broken choss wouldn't have won any awards for alpine finesse, but it did the job.



Annette Plateau from its northern end to Mt Annette (the rock just right of distant Lake Pukaki), Mt Sealy (centre) and the Main Divide (right). Our camp site was at the top end of the skinny black rock island at the top of the Plateau and just right of Sealy

Once safely up on the eastern edge of the Plateau the world took on an entirely different demeanour. Before us stretched a broad, flat expanse of frozen snow and glacial ice, all ringed by rocky walls and peaks. Further in the distance to the north and west towered the Main Divide. It was completely calm and clear, which is how it remained for the next two days.

By now it was after 4pm and we were conscious that our day was drawing to its end. We headed off across the Plateau in search of a suitable spot to pitch our tent. On the way Mike applied his axe to a spot of plumbing work, sculpting a small hollow where glacial melt flowed so we could replenish our drinking water. This was a bonus, as we'd expected that my Jetboil would get a thrashing, melting snow for drinking water. This option was much quicker and easier.

On the south western side of the Plateau we found a rocky outcrop affording both shelter and a series of little pools of clean water – an even easier water source than glacial melt. We pitched our tent, fired up the Jetboil and settled in for a beautiful sunset. The ice cliffs off Sefton and other nearby peaks took on mauve hues, belying the lethal danger that their constant ice avalanches posed.



Our campsite, with Sefton, Footstool, La Perouse, Hicks and Cook



The Milky Way

About 3am Mike grunted into action. His bladder finally drove him from the warmth of his bag and I figured I might as well do the same. Just as well, because a quick look skywards was enough to have me diving for my camera and tripod. The Milky Way and countless other galaxies were spray-painted in silver right across the sky. For once looking relatively tiny, Aoraki and her other 3,000 metre plus companions provided a striking silhouette at the base of this spectacle. I climbed, shivering but smiling, back into my bag about 4.30am.

Being in situ up on the Plateau, we weren't in any hurry next morning. While the youth slept I did get up for dawn and captured another round of beautiful alpine images. Once the sun's rays reached our tent about 8am Mike also roused and we got ready for a primo day in the mountains.

Simon Middlemass had shared some local knowledge with us before we'd set out from Unwin Lodge the morning before, cautioning us about venturing on to the north ridge of Sealy and indeed, anywhere too near the peak, due to high danger of rock fall. With this in mind our commitment to attempting the peak was already low, but we set out westward in the direction of Metelille Glacier to at least take a look.

As is often the case in the mountains, distances proved to be further than they appeared. We reached the cliffs on the western edge of the Plateau and realised that we had two options – either drop down and around the cliffs before re-ascending up the Metelille Glacier to Sladden Saddle, then perhaps, trying Sealy from the south side, or Massey. Or, our second option was to trace the rim of the Plateau southward to Barrow Col, where we could check the north ridge of Sealy out and either try it or back off and complete a full circuit of the Plateau. Option two it was.

Some rock scrambling and cramponing up some steep snow slopes got us up to a high point at 2,450m, just north of Barrow Col. Ahead lay a world of exposure, steepness and choss. Yeah, but nah - we could certainly see what Simon was saying. Once we gave ourselves permission to abandon our north ridge objective all tension fell away and we enjoyed a romp around the rest of the Plateau, taking in the remaining high points on the rim, including Mount Annette.



From our high point, looking along the north ridge of Sealy to Barrow Col and the peak. Mt Massey is further right

From Annette we had a different view of the headwall we'd climbed to access the Plateau the day before and could see why it had felt scary. We also enjoyed ever changing views of Sefton, Aoraki and all the other peaks along and east of the Main Divide. By the time we returned to our campsite about 5.30pm we hadn't climbed anything of note, but it was still a fantastic day out.

Day three we awoke to another calm, crystal clear morning. Our impression from the guide books was that we didn't have anything challenging ahead of us. From the Plateau to Mueller Hut is only about 4km and a 400m drop in height. Mount Kitchener is graded a one. So at 10.30am, we set out in no particular hurry. Dropping across and down the Plateau into new and spectacular terrain was sheer enjoyment, but the closer we got to Kitchener the less assured we were about a nice safe route.



Heading towards Kitchener – the high point in the black mass directly beneath La Perouse

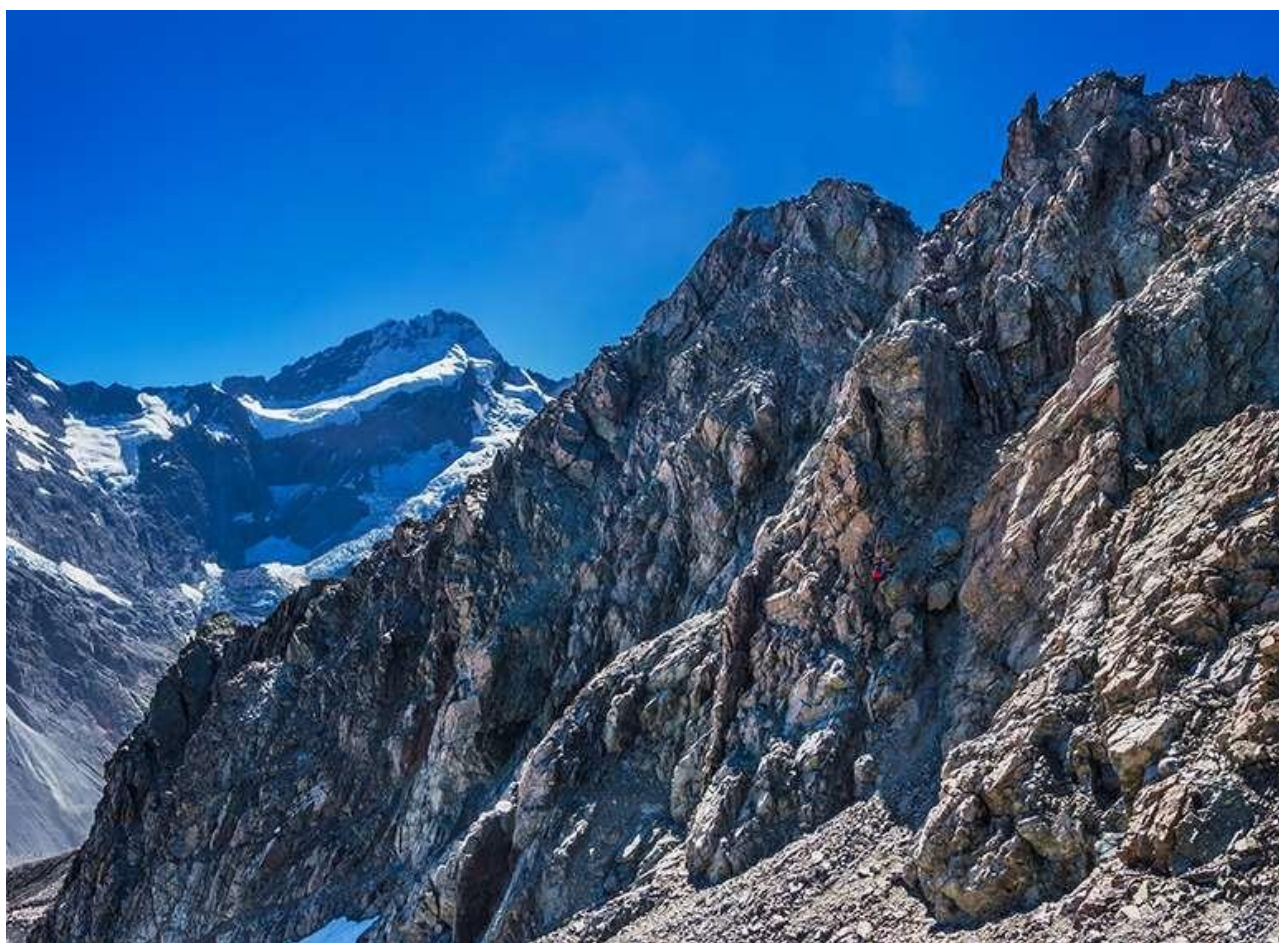
At about 2,000m we stowed our crampons and climbed eastward back up onto the rocky ridge leading over Waihi pass (1,931m) to Kitchener (2,042m). If anything, the condition of the rock down here was at its worst, demanding constant concentration. Everywhere it was bone dry, fractured and tottering, making protection placement very difficult. At one point on a particularly treacherous section I took a short tumble while trying to dodge a rock Mike had accidentally dislodged above me. After that progress slowed further as we had to wait while one descended to a safe spot before the other followed.

We eventually reached the base of the summit cliffs of Kitchener and could see a steep chute that gave access to the summit. But a sheer section about ten metres high looked too daunting.

We tried another line diagonally right but that only ended beneath sheer cliffs. “Hmmm, how can this be a one” we anguished. Surely it must be a winter grade, when there’s a lot more snow about to work with and things are frozen together. Time for lunch and a rethink.

From our sandwich point we just couldn’t see a safe way up. Reluctantly we concluded that the sensible thing to do was to retreat and traverse around on the west side to reach Mueller Hut. We also noted that the top didn’t look particularly friendly either. What if we did manage to climb to the top and there was no way forward? We certainly wouldn’t want to down climb the way we came up without bullet proof protection. So, down we went.

As I passed the steep section beneath the summit chute and saw it from a new perspective I suddenly saw a possible way up and said so. Youthful exuberance kicked in. “I’ll give it a go” and Mike made a beeline to the base of the chute. “Shite, now I’ve done it!”



The youth being exuberant at the base of our crux section on Kitchener

Mike did well, methodically picking his way up, reaching a safe spot to stop so I could follow without having any loose rock topple onto me. Another very airy little move just below the summit on untrustworthy rock saw us on top at about 2pm. And our fear was realised – a very exposed, sheer notch lay between us and the true summit a few metres above us – we couldn’t go forward.

For a fleeting moment I dwelt on the PLB sitting in the top of my pack. No way, I’d never live that one down. Big breaths, map out, take stock. YES! There was a possible escape route down the east side. A chute dropped to slabs fifty metres or so below. They appeared to end in cliffs from where we stood, but the map suggested a better prognosis, so down we went.

Upon reaching the slabs it became apparent that there was a way down to a snow field peppered with fallen rocks, which then led to tussocky shelves. Out of range of any airborne missiles at the bottom of the snow, we stopped for a breather, letting the tension we'd been feeling ease away. It had been a really insightful experience having to pick our own route without any prior instructions. While some people thrive on it, I don't enjoy uncertainty; and when I feel real fear it's probably a signal to myself that I've pushed it a bit too far. I learn more about my emotional limits each time I push my boundaries and Kitchener had unexpectedly done that. I may not like to admit it, but perhaps I'm learning that I'm more a photographer than a climber.

It was nice to get off the really steep stuff, but we weren't quite out of the woods yet. The valley we had ended up in was rapidly culminating in very steep rubble and bluffs. Another look at the map and Mike proposed that we climb out of the valley we were in and join the next, which had slightly more widely spaced contour lines. Good idea Mike – on the ridge between the two valleys we soon saw a monster scree slope extending from Kitchener's ridge top all the way to the valley floor. A few obstacles still had to be overcome, but it was all do-able.



Above, from the neck of the scree slope and, right, our route down from Kitchener. The white arrows indicate a small tussock island that demonstrates how deceiving our top down perspective was



We found ourselves on the narrow neck of the scree slope at 5pm. A cold beer that evening now looked on the cards, which was hugely appealing since we'd just run out of water. From where we stood it looked like we could be down a thousand metres to the valley floor in a couple of hours if the scree was of good quality.

Yeah, but nah. Again the scale of this magnificent landscape completely fooled us. Bruised and battered from countless slips on the horrid, unpredictable rubble (not scree) in our end of day tired state, we trudged in to the Hermitage to get a drink of water in the toilets at 9pm. A few passing restaurant guests gawked, but at least the weather was STILL beautiful and the pub was still serving large jugs of Speights at 10pm when we eventually arrived there. What a day, what a trip. Humbled again. Chhheeeers ☺

For a route map and more images > <http://www.occasionalclimber.co.nz/?p=12424>

East Ridge, Mt Taranaki

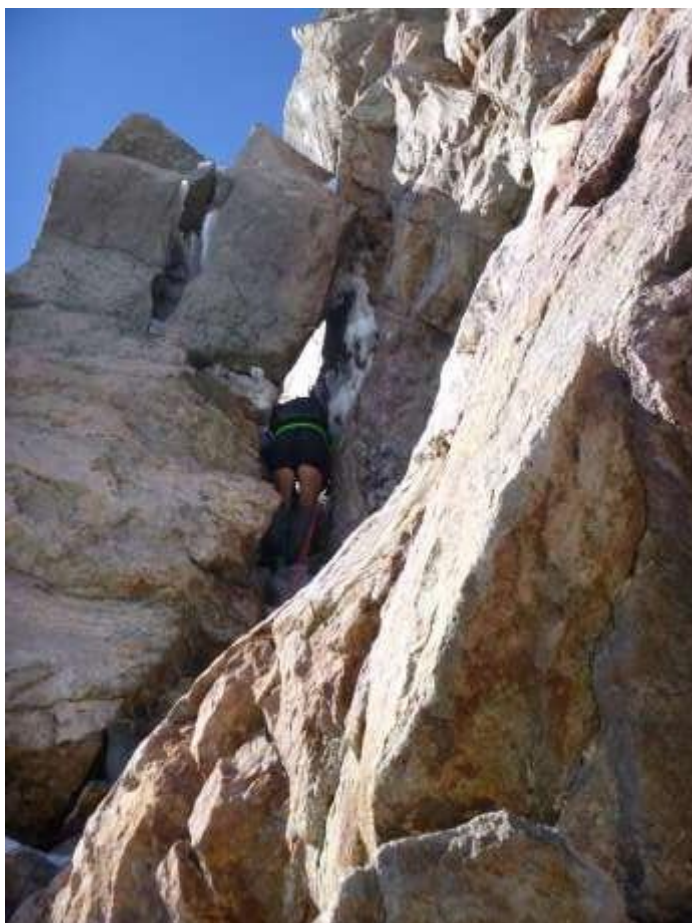
By Carolyn Ellis

The East ridge of Taranaki has been on our list of things to do for a while and we managed to line up a great forecast with a rare free weekend in late April. We headed off to Taranaki on Saturday afternoon and had a meal at Stratford before heading up to park up outside the Stratford Mountain Lodge on Pembroke Road. We'd recently bought a new(er) vehicle so spent the night in relative comfort sleeping in the back. At 5am our alarm went off and we woke to a brilliant starry sky and no wind. After breakfast we sorted out gear and set off from the plateau carpark at 7am. We'd contemplated what gear to carry and made the call to leave crampons behind but carried axes and a rope. Looking up to the Sharks Tooth we could see a bit of snow on the southerly facing aspects but it didn't look too bad. We climbed up through the skifield then headed to the north to make our way around the Policeman. We took a break beside the Policeman to reduce a layer or two. The day was clear and there was a light breeze so it was pretty warm making our way up the East ridge to the Sharks Tooth. We carefully avoided the snowy and icy patches and steadily climbed until we reached the top of the Sharks Tooth at around 10:20. A snack break and a few photos were called for as we basked in the sun – by now the breeze was pretty chilly.



Simon making his way up to the Sharks Tooth

After a period of laziness we made our way northwards along the arete until we reached the chimney which provides access into the crater. We peered down the chimney and noticed that there was quite a buildup of ice – certainly a place where crampons would have been pretty useful. While there is a wire to hang on to assist with the descent I didn't fancy my chances of being able to hang on while my feet were slipping and sliding so we pulled the rope out and did a quick abseil down to get past the ice.



Once down in the crater we joined the mad throngs of tourists and headed up to the summit for an early lunch. As usual on a sunny day it was like a meeting of the United Nations on top – a lot of people moaning and groaning up the last few metres of the climb. We took a few photos and had a leisurely lunch before heading off with the crowd down the scree to Tahurangi Lodge, back on the Round the Mountain track to get to the car before 3. With a stop in Wanganui for dinner we got back to Wellington a little weary at 9pm.

The climb was definitely in summer conditions and would be a completely different experience in the winter – but it was nice to get back into the groove and into the mountains. The benefit of heading up the East Ridge was the almost complete absence of scree to ascend – loads of nice solid rock which was easily scrambled.

McGloin, Easter 2017

By Don French

Tucked away in the Karangarua valley in South Westland is a mountain that has been resting heavily in my mind since an unsuccessful attempt in December 1980. McGloin is 2079 meters, or 2000 meters higher than our starting point. What makes McGloin even more interesting that it appears to have remained unclimbed since its first ascent in 1952, by Wellington section members Maurice Bishop and Trevor McCann. They climbed from the Makawhio (Jacobs) river to the south. The peak has also repulsed other attempts by strong teams of Wellingtonians around this period.

Our team consisted of Wellingtonians John Marshall, Jordi Drouin, and Khan Coleman and Don French, both from the Wairarapa.

The entry into the hills was delayed by a day in order to give the side streams a chance to drop after the recent cyclone dumping. It was an easy first day to Cassel flat. McGloin stands prominently above Cassel flat, which gave us an ideal opportunity to reassess our approach from the safe grounds of the hut door and a borrowed pair of binoculars.

Day two saw us follow the sidle track to the 460m contour. From here the fun began. Dropping off the track to the southwest we crossed Tui creek and then forged our way up a slight spur until we struck the 111m vertical wall which is the largest cascade of the White Rose Falls. The falls offered a spectacular place for lunch with an impressive view looking down the valley. From here we traversed a few hundred meters to the SE crossing under another (dry) waterfall. Immediately after it we picked up a deer trail



View down the Karangarua from the base of the 111m cascade
(credit Khan Coleman)

that climbed very steeply into the sub alpine scrub zone at the 800m contour. We had the pleasure of now having to battle through the leatherwood the few hundred meters (NE) to the base of the 69m cascade of the White Rose Falls. An equally spectacular place for a stop and to recharge the batteries before the next proposition.

We entered the scrub again just to the north of the falls (69m) and began a 100-meter near vertical struggle to pass the falls. Somewhere during this leg, a watch was lost and joined our ever increasing list of gear failures. At the top of this climb our route was abruptly stopped by a small 2½m overhanging cliff. This was finally resolved with a scurry up some trees onto a shoulder and some pack passing. The shoulder revealed a strong animal trail which our battered bodies welcomed.



Idyllic beach camp below the 30m cascade (photo by Khan Coleman)

Another hour on this trail and we found ourselves on another shoulder and the prospect of an uncomfortable camp site. We had only achieved 800 of 1000ms planned climb for the day. But darkness and our wounded bodies demanded the stop for the night. While on the search for water we discovered a beach at the base of the 30ms falls which offered us a soft and comfortable night. Too good to refuse. The only problem was that if it rained and the creek rose a few centimeters we'd find ourselves in a great deal of strife.

On reflection that day was one of my hardest off track days for a number of years. The real hero of the day was the pruning saw which probably made the distance we covered possible.

Summit day was going to be without John, who was starting to find the mountain a bit more committing than he'd anticipated, so he had decided to sit it out. Meanwhile the other three climbed up through the final 200ms of leatherwood onto open ground.

Decision time. We had originally planned to use an approach by the SE ridge, but the early morning light was illuminating it as a serious proposition. Scanning the cirque revealed the only other hint of weakness, being a snow grass lead through the middle of the bluffs. The only problem with that route was that it was hinting at ending in a vertical rock wall with a couple of small patches of green to break the expanse. So it was with trepidation the three harnessed up and approached the line.

The first 100 meters passed very quickly with a series of well-placed steps kicked into the mossy surface, and scrambles over wet slabs. The ground steepened until we found ourselves at the base of the rock headwall standing on a small grassy shoulder to its right. The rope was required to sneak onto the slabs around the corner and up a short corner for 20 meters which was our only option. Another corner saw a 25 meter wet greasy chimney appear. This took 4 attempts and an hour and half before we finally saw the route established through the cirque and onto easier ground. The crux!



Jordi starts the climb through the impressive buttress on the summit cone (credit Don French)

Things moved fairly quickly from that point, and we passed over the east ridge of the unclimbed Mt Glower into the upper snow fields. It was well after midday when we broke the 2000m contour and obtained the crest of McGloin's south ridge. The impressive southern buttress was easily passed with a few pitches of relatively easy and pleasant climbing. We knew we were close. Ahead of us was a beautiful, but unprotected, slab leading to a summit.

Unfortunately, this summit revealed another 3 pitches to the true summit, which was estimated to be only a few meters higher. The rock slabs on the western side of the ridge were appalling, while the more solid eastern side had now tilted itself into a vertical position. It was 2pm, our latest possible turnaround time, and only 4 hours away from darkness. Hence we had no option but to turn for home.



Slabs to the summit? (credit Khan Coleman)

By the time we found ourselves at the top of the greasy chimney we estimated we had only an hour and a half of daylight left, which allowed (just) enough time to do the three abseils and down climb the tricky snowgrass slope to easier ground in the twilight. We dug a turf bollard and

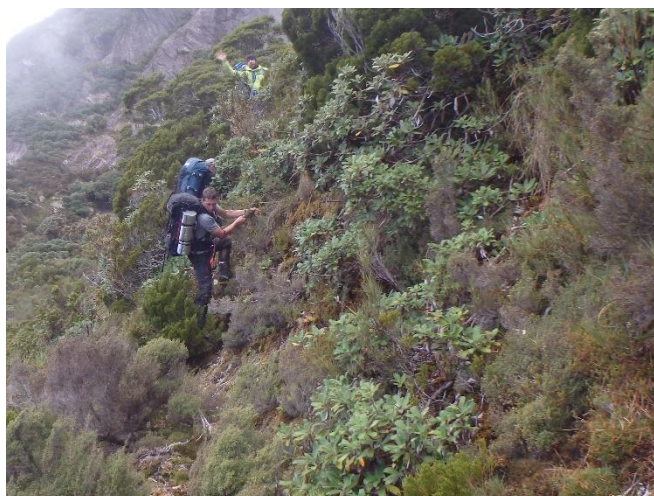


The troublesome turf bollard (credit Khan Coleman)

dropped down the first abseil, only to find that we'd miscalculated the resistance of the turf bollard on our rope, and we could not retrieve it. Buggar! Buggar! Buggar! No warm sleeping bags for us tonight. We ascended the rope and proceeded to find ourselves a comfortable posy for the night. Sunrise was a very long 770 minutes away after sunset. The temperature dropped from 6 to 2 degrees at dawn. We shivered and suffered to a very long and starry night.

Sunshine saw us acting like reptiles at first before we continued to retreat back to our high camp meeting a concerned John enroute.

We spent another comfortable night at our high camp before starting the process of returning to civilisation.



Aping it through the leatherwood on the descent. (credit Don French)

Postscript. Three of us later attempted Mt Rolleston via Rome ridge, only to be defeated by old (hard) glacier ice and some end of season difficulties.

Thanks to all on the trip, and a very special credit has to go to the pruning saw who made it all possible.



The White Rose Falls route is marked, with the position of high camp marked. Marking stops at the entrance to the cirque

Notices

2017 Remarkables Ice and Mixed Climbing Festival – 17-20 August

The Remarkables Ice and Mixed Climbing Festival is the annual climbing meet of the Expedition Climbers Club Incorporated. This festival :

- Brings together a huge cross section of climbers from around NZ and the world. Beginners get to rub shoulders and share the rope with the top winter alpine climbers in NZ.
- Offers clinics, competitions, races and social gatherings to advance and promote modern mixed climbing.
- Showcases the new and existing route potential on NZ's most accessible multi-pitch winter training area, the Remarkables.
- Shares local knowledge and forms new climbing partnerships.
- Fundraises for the ECC Expedition Capital Fund.

You need to be a club member to attend this event. Those who wish to join can visit the registration page of [this website](#). You can join the club and register for a clinic all on one simple form.

Information on the event can be found at www.iceandmixedfestival.co.nz

Fluoro Block Party in New Plymouth 9 July

The YMCA Taranaki and The Crux Climbing Gym are running New Zealand's first Black Light Pump Fest Style Bouldering Competition on Sunday 9 July (first weekend of the school holidays). For more information about this fun event, click [here](#).

Wellington Section 2017 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Co Chair	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Treasurer (Acting)	Peter Laurenson	
Secretary & Vertigo editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
Other Committee Members	Elisha Watson	
	Matt Pemberton	
	Sandy Britain	
	Alex Waterford	
Rock Drill Overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 55 55 893

www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Twitter @NZACWellington



Shed 6 Queens Wharf
Wellingtons Waterfront
Ph 04 4998898 Fax 04 4998896
wn@fergskayaks.co.nz
www.fergskayaks.co.nz

Open 7 Days

Largest Real Rock Indoor Rock Wall – Kayaking – Inline Skates – Retail – Rental

Alpine Club members can climb any time for \$12
Monday nights show your Alpine Club card and climb for \$10

New routes every week*

\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012

New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

Creating happiness through
better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



**HangDog Rock Climbing
Adventures**

453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181
info@hangdog.co.nz

www.hangdog.co.nz

i climb
co.nz

Simond alpine equipment direct from the importer



Ocelot
\$115



MXC 820
\$230



Makalu
\$255



Caiman
\$230

all crampons include anti-balling plates
and crampon bag



i climb
co.nz